

Photographs by A PRABHAKAR RAO



Golden FLEECE

Theft of jewellery by the chief priest of Tirupati's Sri Kodandaramaswami temple exposes mismanagement of the shrines and their wealth. Politicians make hay.

| By Amarnath K. Menon |

For countless devotees and the Tirumala-Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), managers of 28 temples, including the richest shrine atop Tirumala, it was a huge embarrassment. While drawing up the inventory of the ornaments of the Sri Kodandaramaswami temple in Tirupati, the appraisers of the TTD found that the temple's chief priest had stolen 12 gold and stone-studded ornaments, weighing more than 1,700 gm. He had pledged them to raise Rs 10.15 lakh for the marriage of his daughters. Though some may brush it aside as an act of temporary misappropriation, for the priest had

already redeemed a portion by paying back the pawnbrokers Rs 3.50 lakh and putting some jewellery back in the temple, the scandal brings alive the pathetic plight of priests and the mismanagement of the temples and their wealth due to lax administration compounded by archaic practices.

In swift retribution, the priest, A.P. Venkataramana Dikshitulu, and the pawnbrokers—Sagarmal and Raghava Reddy—were arrested and the entire jewellery restored to the temple. Further, the TTD suspended the temple inspector for alleged dereliction of duty. "I have not done anything wrong. Have you not committed mistakes?" asked the priest when questioned. The discovery follows a

directive of the Andhra Pradesh High Court to inventory the jewellery and other precious ornaments of the TTD and submit it to the court.

The manner in which the TTD does the inventory speaks for itself. There is only one appraiser for all 28 temples and the inventory process is done by him once a year in the presence of a vigilance officer, financial adviser and chief accounts officer appointed by the Centre. The financial adviser's post has been vacant for the last six months.

The poor administration of the temples is acknowledged by those working for the TTD at various levels. The deputy executive officers saddled with the charge of supervising the temples in and around Tirupati have